



Impressive effort: Rajasthan United, a second-division side, impressed in the Super Cup, beating Mumbai City FC in the group stages. RUFC MEDIA

blaring music and idling team buses.

East Bengal supporters attempted to highlight the situation by displaying a 'Save Indian Football' banner before their semifinal, but it was forcibly removed within minutes. Then, there was the football. While Catala was right to criticise the tournament conditions, he would still regret the missed chance to secure Kerala Blasters' maiden title. The team was in prime position to reach the semifinals for the first time, but a needless red card for Sandeep Singh and a late own goal allowed Mumbai City FC to advance.

"We were lucky enough to have this tournament, so we have to appreciate every single moment. We know it's only a matter of time before football comes back," said a hopeful Petr Kratky, Mumbai City's head coach, whose side lost in the semifinals to FC Goa.

Kratky's squad did well to

compete with the defending champion despite spending more than 12 hours stranded at the Mumbai airport due to IndiGo's operational crisis. The team landed in Goa at 2 a.m. and reached its hotel at 4 a.m., just 16 hours before kickoff. The two finalists, FC Goa and East Bengal, appeared better prepared, with FC Goa benefiting from continental competition and East Bengal gaining minutes through the Durand Cup and the IFA Shield.

FC Goa had the slight advantage of playing at home, which proved decisive. After 120 goalless minutes, FC Goa edged the penalty shootout as Mohammad Rashid and PV Vishnu missed their attempts.

"Today, I think the fans made the difference, 100 per cent. In so many moments of the game, it made a difference (sic)," said Bino George, East Bengal's assistant coach.

Brison Fernandes, Ayush Dev Chhetri, Ronney Wilson and Hrithik Tiwari were central to FC Goa's back-to-back triumphs, with Marquez continuing his habit of trusting young domestic talent.

"But you need football. It's too much time without football for some



Desperate appeal: "Just a call... I am begging them," urged Punjab FC head coach, Panagiotis Dilmperis. "If you love Indian football, you have to find a solution." AIFF MEDIA

players. You cannot go eight months without games. We need to play as soon as possible," Marquez said when asked whether he can keep giving opportunities to emerging Indian players.

Even as the confetti settles, the Super Cup champion and the larger ecosystem are left wondering what comes next, with the Master Rights Agreement between Football Development for Sports Limited and the AIFF having expired the following day. India's places in Asian competitions are also at risk if top-flight teams fail to play at least 27 matches this season, under Criterion 4. a of the AFC Club Competitions Entry Regulations 2023.

"Just a call... I am begging them," said Punjab FC head coach Panagiotis Dilmperis. "If you love Indian football, you have to find a solution."

With the national team at its lowest point in nearly a decade, a handful of matches will not change much. The players did what they could in difficult circumstances. It is now up to the stakeholders who matter to act with urgency.